Leng Rohaniah Guro Magarang

Leng Rohaniah Guro Magarang (also known as **Leng Rohann** and affectionately called **Lengleng**) is a Maranao chef-entrepreneur, community leader, culinary peace advocate, and government employee based in Iligan City, Lanao del Norte. She is the founder and owner of Kitchenommy Delights, and has served as the elected president of the Iligan Hotels and Resorts Restaurants Association (IHARRA) for six consecutive years. A working solo parent who built her culinary career from a childhood spent in her grandmother's kitchen, she is best known for championing the philosophy of "food for peace," using halal cuisine as a bridge between Muslims, Christians, and indigenous peoples across Northern Mindanao.

Recognized by USAID as an Empowered Woman and honored by Nestlé Halal Philippines and One Halal Global as a Chef Ambassador, she has brought Bangsamoro and Iligan cuisines to international stages, including the International Battle of the Chefs in Penang, Malaysia. Her decade-long Free Iftar Program, her disaster relief operations, and her youth culinary training initiatives have made her one of the most consequential figures in Mindanao's food and community empowerment landscape.

Contents

1 Early Life and Heritage
2 Education and Early Training
3 Career
    3.1 Burp Diner and the Road to Kitchenommy
    3.2 Restaurant Consultancy
    3.3 Government Service
    3.4 IHARRA Leadership
4 Culinary Philosophy and Signature Dishes
5 Community Initiatives
    5.1 Free Iftar Program
    5.2 Disaster Relief Operations
    5.3 Interfaith Culinary Advocacy
    5.4 Youth Empowerment Through Food
    5.5 Nestlé Halal Cooking Demonstrations
6 Ambassadorial Roles
7 Recognition and Awards
8 Personal Life
9 Cultural Significance
10 See Also
11 Further Reading

Early Life and Heritage

Leng Rohaniah Guro Magarang was born in Butlig, Lanao del Sur, into a family where cooking wasn't just a skill, it was a way of keeping the peace.<ref name="tribune2024">Template:Cite web</ref>

Her family's torogan, the traditional ancestral home of Maranao nobility, was renowned throughout the community for the quality of its food. And this reputation did real work: warring parties who entered the dining hall laid down their arms. Differences were settled not at the negotiating table but over her grandmother's cooking.<ref name="tribune2024" />

Growing up in that environment, Leng didn't play with ordinary toys. While her grandmother measured and stirred, young Leng was right there beside her, playing with miniature kitchen sets, already learning by instinct that cooking was her calling.<ref name="tribune2024" />

Her nickname, "Lengleng," is a warm derivative of *malingkat,* a Tausug word that means beautiful, and it captures the affection with which her community has always regarded her.<ref name="tribune2024" />

Leng Rohaniah Guro Magarang



Born	Butlig, Lanao del Sur, Philippines
Nationality	Filipino
Ethnicity	Maranao
Religion	Islam
Occupation(s)	Chef-entrepreneur, government employee, culinary educator, community leader
Known for	Kitchenommy Delights; IHARRA presidency; Free Iftar Program; food peace advocacy
Spouse	Abdul Salam Magarang (m. 2009)
Awards	USAID Empowered Woman; Philippine Halal Excellence Award for Community Service; Higala Communities Empowered Women 2026

Education and Early Training

Leng's formal culinary education was not the conventional restaurant-school path. She started her hands-on training as an apprentice to chef Dennis Barazon, assisting in cooking demonstrations focused on Malaysian cuisine and everyday Filipino staples. That early exposure to cross-cultural cooking would later define her signature style.<ref name="tribune2024" />

In 2014, she took a short culinary course at the Alternative Learning School in Iligan City, formalizing skills she had been refining since childhood.<ref name="tribune2024" />

Career

Burp Diner and the Road to Kitchenommy

In 2015, Leng co-founded Burp Diner in Iligan alongside a classmate and two professional chefs. The restaurant carved a niche serving students in the city, with its standout item being Albaik chicken, a version of breaded fried chicken inspired by the famous Saudi fast-food chain Albaik. Muslim pilgrims returning from Mecca raved about the original, brought her samples, and Leng developed her own version that closely matched the original's taste.<ref name="tribune2024" />

The Marawi Siege of 2017 disrupted the business severely, as it did for countless entrepreneurs in Northern Mindanao. But Leng and her business partner Angelica Dagondon kept going by pivoting to catering work for fundraising events, including events hosted by prominent names such as Senator Tito Sotto and actor Kier Legaspi. Many friends and relatives displaced by the siege found comfort in Leng's kitchen during this difficult period.<ref name="tribune2024" />

When the COVID-19 pandemic hit, she set up Kitchenommy Cocina Studio at her husband's office as an improvised commissary. During Ramadan, orders for iftar meals poured in, proving the demand was there. But family concerns about viral exposure pushed her to look for a more permanent space. She returned to the old Burp

Diner building, reopened the kitchen, and gave jobs to former workers who had lost their livelihoods during the pandemic, initially paying them in free meals until the delivery business stabilized. Eventually, the team received professional wages.<ref name="tribune2024" />

Kitchenommy Delights grew steadily. It is now a concessionaire at Mindanao State University Iligan Institute of Technology (MSU-IIT), serving students through its signature chicken wing variants.<ref name="tribune2024" />

Restaurant Consultancy

Beyond running her own kitchen, Leng has built a respected restaurant consultancy practice. She works with establishments on menu design, staff training, hospitality standards upgrading, and the organization of culinary events and competitions. As IHARRA president, she also makes rounds of Iligan City's restaurants to check on food safety and industry standards.<ref name="tribune2024" />

Government Service

Leng is also a government employee, though specific details about her government position have not been publicly disclosed in available sources. This dual life as a public servant and private entrepreneur reflects her broader orientation: using every platform available to serve her community.

IHARRA Leadership

Leng was elected president of the Iligan Hotels and Resorts Restaurants Association (IHARRA), a post she has held for six consecutive years.<ref name="sourceprofile">Leng Rohaniah Guro Magarang professional profile document, provided by subject.</ref> Under her leadership, IHARRA has become more than a trade association. It has served as a platform for culinary competitions to elevate local cuisines, a hub for industry training, and a headquarters kitchen during disaster relief operations.

One of her most significant achievements as IHARRA head was organizing a culinary training program for out-of-school youth under the USAID Opportunity 2.0 Program, working alongside Iligan Mayor Frederick Siao. IHARRA members committed to helping program graduates find employment after completing their training.<ref name="tribune2024" />

She also served as Former President of Rotary East Iligan, extending her community leadership beyond the culinary sector into broader civic service.<ref name="sourceprofile" />

Culinary Philosophy and Signature Dishes

Leng's cooking philosophy is rooted in a simple but powerful idea: halal food is food for everyone. She believes that when people sit together and share a meal, differences dissolve. This isn't just ideology for her; it comes from lived experience in her grandmother's torogan, where the same principle played out across generations.<ref name="tribune2024" />

Her signature dish is **Chicken Pindiyalokan**, a Maranao preparation of chicken cooked with palapa, the iconic condiment made from ginger, shallots, turmeric, chilies, and shredded coconut. She also prepares a **Roasted Pindiyalokan** variant that has drawn attention at public culinary events.<ref name="tribune2024" />

> "I always dedicate my food to everyone to promote peace." — Chef Leng Rohaniah Guro Magarang, as quoted in the *Daily Tribune*, January 2024

> "Strength isn't about standing alone, it's about building a table where everyone has a place." — Kitchenommy Delights

Her dishes have been featured in the *Daily Tribune* and showcased at the International Battle of the Chefs in Penang, Malaysia, where she represented both Bangsamoro and Iligan cuisines on an international stage.<ref name="sourceprofile" /><ref name="tribune2024" />

Community Initiatives

Free Iftar Program

For ten consecutive years, Leng has personally prepared and distributed free iftar meals, the evening meal that breaks the daily fast during Ramadan, to communities in need, including the Torel Orphanage and local mosques. <ref name="sourceprofile" /> This program has become one of the most sustained individual charitable feeding initiatives in Iligan City.

Disaster Relief Operations

When Typhoon Basyang struck, Leng mobilized Kitchenommy Delights and IHARRA's resources to serve as the association's headquarters kitchen for relief operations, producing and distributing thousands of hot meals to typhoon victims. This relief work is ongoing, reflecting her view that a professional kitchen is a community resource in times of crisis.<ref name="sourceprofile" />

Interfaith Culinary Advocacy

In December 2023, following a bombing at Mindanao State University in Lanao del Sur that claimed four lives, Leng joined the Tri-People Cuisine for Interfaith Solidarity event at The Alemania Hotel in Iligan City. The event, organized during the island's annual Week of Peace, brought together Muslim, Christian, and Higaunon Lumad chefs to cook and share food as a collective act of mourning and hope. Leng prepared her signature Chicken Pindiyalokan and Roasted Pindiyalokan for the occasion.<ref name="uri2024">Template:Cite web</ref>

The event was a collaboration between Pakigdait, Inc., IHARRA, the Iligan City Tourism Office, and other civic groups, and it drew attendance from security sector members of the PNP and the AFP, indigenous elders, city officials, media, and youth.<ref name="uri2024" />

Youth Empowerment Through Food

Through the USAID Opportunity 2.0 Program, Leng channeled IHARRA's resources into vocational culinary training for out-of-school youth. The commitment extended beyond skills training: IHARRA members pledged to help graduates find actual employment.<ref name="tribune2024" />

> "I couldn't give them dole-outs, but I could teach them how to cook. Many have since gotten jobs as a result." — Chef Leng Rohaniah Guro Magarang, as quoted in the *Daily Tribune*, January 2024

Nestlé Halal Cooking Demonstrations

As a Chef Ambassador for Nestlé Halal Philippines, Leng has led halal cooking demonstrations that bring professional culinary education to wider audiences, helping normalize halal standards in mainstream food culture.<ref name="sourceprofile" />

Ambassadorial Roles

Leng has served as Chef Ambassador for two major halal food organizations:

Nestlé Halal Philippines — Her role involves promoting halal cooking standards and demonstrating how mainstream food brands can integrate halal practices seamlessly.<ref name="sourceprofile" />

One Halal Global — This international platform gave her a broader reach to advocate for Bangsamoro and Filipino halal cuisine on a global stage.<ref name="sourceprofile" />

She also serves as Chef Consultant for IHARRA, advising on culinary programming and hospitality standards for the association's member establishments.<ref name="sourceprofile" />

Recognition and Awards

Leng's work has earned her recognition from both domestic and international organizations:

- **USAID Empowered Woman Award** for strengthening community resilience and empowering people through food and culinary heritage.<ref name="sourceprofile" />
- **Philippine Halal Excellence Award for Community Service** for her sustained advocacy in halal cuisine and community feeding programs.<ref name="sourceprofile" />
- **Higala Communities Initiative Inc. Empowered Women 2026** award, recognizing her as a standout empowered woman in her community.<ref name="sourceprofile" />
- Featured in the *Daily Tribune* for her signature regional dishes and her community service model.<ref name="tribune2024" />

Personal Life

Leng married Abdul Salam Magarang in 2009, a contractor and a second cousin of her mother. She is a working solo parent, managing her restaurant enterprise, consultancy work, and government duties alongside raising her child.<ref name="tribune2024" />

Her Muslim faith is integral to her identity as a chef. Halal cooking isn't simply a market category for her; it's an expression of her values, her heritage, and her belief that food prepared with care and conscience nourishes more than the body. Ramadan, with its rhythms of fasting and feasting, is one of the most active periods in her kitchen, both commercially and in terms of charitable work.<ref name="sourceprofile" />

Cultural Significance

Leng Rohaniah Guro Magarang stands at the intersection of several important conversations in contemporary Philippine society. She is a Maranao woman who navigated a male-dominated industry, rebuilt a business through a siege and a pandemic, and emerged as one of the most recognized voices in Northern Mindanao's food scene.

Her work speaks directly to the challenge of inter-communal peace in a region that has experienced decades of conflict. By positioning the dining table as a place of reconciliation, she draws on a tradition that goes back to her grandmother's torogan, where warring parties once set down their weapons to eat together. This is not symbolic performance for Leng; it's a working methodology that she deploys through events, programs, and her daily cooking practice.

She also represents a model of leadership that doesn't separate professional excellence from social responsibility. Kitchenommy Delights is simultaneously a restaurant, a relief kitchen, a training ground, and an expression of Bangsamoro culinary heritage.

See Also

- Maranao cuisine
- Iligan City
- Bangsamoro cuisine
- Halal food in the Philippines
- Palapa (condiment)
- Iligan Hotels and Resorts Restaurants Association
- USAID Opportunity 2.0 Program
- Marawi Siege

Further Reading

- "Cooking to Serve the Community." *Daily Tribune Lifestyle,* January 20, 2024. https://lifestyle.tribune.net.ph/cooking-to-serve-the-community/
- "Tri-People Cuisine for Peace and Solidarity." United Religions Initiative, January 9, 2024. https://www.uri.org/uri-story/20240109-tri-people-cuisine-peace-and-solidarity

Editorial Notice: BangsamoroPedia is a curated knowledge archive. Its pages are maintained by the editorial administrator to help ensure historical accuracy. If you would like to suggest corrections, share sources, or contribute information, please message the administrator through the official Facebook page: **Notable Muslim Filipinos**.

Retrieved from "https://wiki.maranaw.com/index.php?title=Leng_Rohaniah_Guro_Magarang&oldid=1351"